Introduction to Film Studies

FILM 1020E (002)
Western University
Department of Film Studies 2013/2014

***Course Aims*:**
Film 1020E is designed as a broad introduction to an interrelated set of approaches in film studies, all of them defined by their treatment of cinema as an art form. The course begins with an extended examination of the elements of film form and style, providing students the tools to analyze films. It then shifts focus and investigates different types of films – from live action to animated, fictional to documentary, classical to postmodern, narrative to experimental – as well as the various critical approaches that have shaped the ideas and methods of film scholars. By the end of this course, successful students will have gained not only an appreciation of cinema in all its dimensions, but also a capacity to recognize and communicate with clarity and concision the meanings and affects of this commercial and personal art form.

Learning Outcomes:
To develop critical awareness of film as an artistic medium, refine critical thinking skills, and learn how to analyze film language (the construction of film images, systems of film editing, film sound, and the varied modes of organizing these core elements (narrative, non-narrative, etc.).

Instructor

Professor Benjamin Wright
E-mail: bwrigh25@uwo.ca
Office Hours: Wednesdays 1:30-3:30
Office Location: UC 69

Teaching Assistants

Charlotte W.: cwarr2@uwo.ca
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Meeting Times

LECTURE: Wednesdays 3:30-4:30 PM
SCREENING: Tuesdays 6-9 PM
TUTORIAL (**Check your schedule**): W 4:30-5:30 / 5:30-6:30 / 6:30-7:30
TH 9:30-10:30 / 10:30-11:30

Required Texts

David Bordwell and Kristin Thompson. Film Art: An Introduction. 10th ed. New York: McGraw-Hill Inc., 2012. (**BT**)

Course Package (**CP)**

The textbook is available at the campus bookstore. The course package is available at the custom course books office in the bookstore.

Grade Breakdown

Fall Term (35%)
Attendance and Tutorial Participation: 5%
Midterm Test #1: 5% (**October 22 in Screening**)
Essay #1: Mise-en-scène Analysis (1000 words) 10% (**Due Nov. 6 in Lecture**)
Essay #2: Sequence Analysis (1500 words plus Shot Breakdown) 15% (**Due Nov. 27 in Lecture**)

Winter Term (35%)
Attendance and Tutorial Participation: 5%
Midterm Test #2: 10% (**February 4 in Screening**)
Essay #3: Research Essay (1500 words) 20% (**Due March 19 in Lecture**)

Final Examination: 30%

Paper Requirements
Students will write three (3) papers over the course of the year. Each essay assignment must be typed, double-spaced, using 12-point Times Roman font and 1-inch margins.

All papers must be submitted at the end of the Tutorial section on their specified due dates. Papers will not be accepted if they are e-mailed or turned in to the Department office. Late papers will receive a deduction of a full letter grade for every week they are overdue. Exceptions will be made only in the event of a documented medical or family emergency.

Notes on Citations and Outside Research
All research incorporated into the essay assignments must be accompanied by a bibliography and citations using a standard academic format. MLA, APA, and Chicago are all acceptable. Failure to include citations for course material and outside research may result in a failing grade for the assignment and could lead to an investigation of plagiarism. If you are unsure what constitutes an acceptable academic source, consult Dr. Wright. Under no circumstance should Wikipedia or other user-generated websites be used.

Midterms and Final Examination
The midterm tests and final exam will deal with information from lectures, readings, assignments, handouts, and screenings. For a missed exam, you must inform the professor before an exam and present verifiable evidence in order to schedule a make-up exam. Students who wish to take an incomplete must also present documentation to Dr. Wright.

E-mail
Although your TAs and I will try to answer e-mails in a timely fashion, we cannot guarantee any response within a set time frame. If you have a time-dependent matter to discuss, please see one of us during an office hour or make an appointment for another convenient time. We do not accept assignments by e-mail.

Cell Phones
Cell phones are to be turned off for class. People who text or receive calls during class will be asked to leave and need permission to re-enter the course.

Laptop Computers
Unless otherwise specified by the instructor, laptops are for taking lecture and tutorial notes only. Anyone found using their laptop for email, unauthorized browsing, etc. will have their privilege revoked for the duration of the academic year and will not be permitted to bring a laptop to class.

OWL
All assignments and announcements will be posted to OWL for your convenience.

Course Schedule

WEEK 1 (September 10-12) INTRODUCTION: FILM AS ART
Screening: *Apocalypse Now* (1979, Francis Ford Coppola, USA – Theatrical Version)
Reading: BT: pp. 2-46.

FILM FORM: NARRATIVE AND STYLE

WEEK 2 (September 17-19) NARRATIVE AND NARRATION
Screening: *Citizen Kane* (1942, Orson Welles, USA)
Reading: BT: pp. 72-110.

WEEK 3 (September 24-26) MISE-EN-SCENE
Screening: *The Rules of the Game* (1939, Jean Renoir, France)
Reading: BT: pp. 112-158.

WEEK 4 (October 1-3) CINEMATOGRAPHY

Screening: *The Red Shoes* (1948, Michael Powell and Emeric Pressburger, UK)
Reading: BT: pp. 160-217.

WEEK 5 (October 8-10) EDITING I
Screening: *The Maltese Falcon* (1941, John Huston, USA)
Reading: BT: pp. 218-254.

WEEK 6 (October 15-17) EDITING II
Screening: *Breathless* (1960, Jean Luc Godard, France)
Reading: BT: pp. 242-265.

WEEK 7 (October 22-24) SOUND
Midterm Test #1
Screening: *A Man Escaped* (1956, Robert Bresson, France)
Reading: BT: pp. 266-307.

WEEK 8 (October 29-31) MUSIC
NOTE: All tutorials are canceled this week for Fall Break
Screening: *The Adventures of Robin Hood* (1939, Michael Curtiz, USA)
Reading: CP: Kalinak "The Classical Film Score."

WEEK 9 (November 5-7) REALISM
Essay #1
Screening: *Umberto D* (1955, Vittorio De Sica, Italy)
Reading: CP: Selections by André Bazin.

WEEK 10 (November 12-14) FORMALISM & SEMIOTICS
Screening: *Battleship Potemkin* (1925, Sergei Eisenstein, Soviet Union)
Reading: CP: Sergei Eisenstein, "The Cinematographic Principle and the Ideogram," and "A Dialectical Approach to Film Form"; Christian Metz, "Some Points in the Semiotics of Cinema."

FILM FORM: TYPES OF FILMS

WEEK 11 (November 19-21) DOCUMENTARY
Screening: *The Thin Blue Line* (1988, Errol Morris, USA)
Reading: BT: pp. 350-369; 433-439; CP: Bill Nichols, "Introduction."

WEEK 12 (November 26-28) EXPERIMENTAL & AVANT GARDE
Essay #2
Screening: *Un Chien Andalou* (1929, Luis Bunuel, France); *Meshes of the Afternoon* (1943, Maya Deren, USA); *A Movie* (1958, Bruce Conner, USA); *Mothlight* (1963, Stan Brakhage, USA); *La Jetee* (1962, Chris Marker, France).
Reading: BT: pp. 369-387.

WEEK 13 (December 3-5) ANIMATION

Screening: *Fantasia* (1941, Walt Disney, USA); *Ryan* (2004, Chris Landreth, Canada); *Day and Night* (2010, Teddy Newton, USA)
Reading: BT: pp. 387-398; CP: Thompson, "Implications of the Cell Animation Technique."

ACROSS THE MEDIUM: MODES OF FILMMAKING

WEEK 14 (January 7-9) EARLY CINEMA
Screening: A Selection of Lumiere Brothers shorts (*The Kiss*; *Arrival of a Train at La Ciotat*; *Workers Leaving the Factory*); *A Trip to the Moon* (1902, Georges Melies, France); *The Great Train Robbery* (1903, Edwin S. Porter, USA); *Rescued by Rover* (Cecil M. Hepworth, UK); *The Life of an American Fireman* (1903, Edwin S. Porter, USA); *The Lonedale Operator* (1911, D.W. Griffith, USA); *The Immigrant* (1916, Charles Chaplin, USA)
Reading: BT: 462-466; CP: Tom Gunning, "An Aesthetic of Astonishment."

WEEK 15 (January 14-16) CLASSICAL CINEMA
Screening: *Casablanca* (1942, Michael Curtiz, USA)
Reading: CP: David Bordwell, "An excessively obvious cinema" and "The formulation of the classical narrative."

WEEK 16 (January 21-23) POSTMODERN CINEMA
Screening: *Medium Cool* (1969, Haskell Wexler, USA)
Reading: CP: John Hill, "Film and Postmodernism."

WEEK 17 (January 28-30) ART CINEMA
Screening: *L'Avventura* (1960, Michelangelo Antonioni, Italy)
Reading: CP: Bordwell "Art Cinema Narration."

WEEK 18 (February 4-6) RADICAL CINEMA
Midterm Test #2
Screening: *Tout va bien* (1972, Jean Luc Godard, France)
Reading: CP: Jean-Luc Comolli and Jean Narboni "Cinema/Ideology/Criticism."

ACROSS THE MEDIUM: GENRE, AUTEURISM, NATIONAL CINEMA

WEEK 19 (February 11-13) GENRE I: The Horror Film
Screening: *Halloween* (1978, John Carpenter, USA)
Reading: CP: Thomas Schatz, "Film Genre"; Carol Clover, "Her Body, Himself: Gender in the Slasher Film."

Reading Week (February 17-21)

WEEK 20 (February 25-27) GENRE II: The Gangster Film

Screening: *White Heat* (1947, Raoul Walsh, USA)
Reading: CP: Robert Warshow, "The Gangster as Tragic Hero."

WEEK 21 (March 4-6) AUTEURISM
Screening: *Rear Window* (1953, Alfred Hitchcock, USA)
Reading: CP: Andrew Sarris, "Notes on the Auteur Theory in 1962"; David Sterritt, "Introduction" to *Hitchcock's Films*.

WEEK 22 (March 11-13) NATIONAL CINEMA: CANADA
Screening: *Bon Cop, Bad Cop* (2006, Erik Canuel, Canada)
Reading: CP: Will Straw "Canadian Cinema"

ACROSS THE MEDIUM: FILM AND THE SOCIAL WORLD

WEEK 23 (March 18-20) FEMINIST CRITICISM & PSYCHOANALYSIS
Essay #3
Screening: *Haywire* (2011, Steven Soderbergh, USA)
Reading: CP: Laura Mulvey, "Visual Pleasure and Narrative Cinema."

WEEK 24 (March 25-27) GLOBAL CINEMA
Screening: *City of God* (2002, Fernando Meirelles, Katia Lund, Brazil)
Reading: CP: Fernando Solanas and Octavio Gettino, "Towards a Third Cinema."

WEEK 25 (April 1-3) DIGITAL CINEMA
Screening: *The Celebration* (1998, Thomas Vinterberg, Denmark)
Reading: CP: Dogme 95 Manifesto

Important Information for Students

1. Plagiarism: Plagiarism is a major academic offence. Students must write their essays in their own words. Whenever students take an idea, or a passage, from another author, they must acknowledge their debt both by using quotation marks where appropriate and by proper referencing such as footnotes or citations. www.uwo.ca/univsec/handbook/appeals/scholastic_discipline_undergrad.pdf

2. Plagiarism Checking: If you plan to use Plagiarism checking software in your course, you must include the following passage on your syllabus: All required papers may be subject to submission for textual similarity review to the commercial plagiarism detection software under license to the University for the detection of plagiarism. All papers submitted will be included as source documents in the reference database for the purpose of detecting plagiarism of papers subsequently submitted to the system. Use of the service is subject to the licensing agreement, currently between the University of Western Ontario and Turnitin.com.

3. Prerequisites: Unless you have either the requisites for this course or written special permission from your Dean to enroll in it, you will be removed from this course and it will be deleted from your record. The decision may not be appealed. You will receive no adjustment to your fees in the event that you are dropped from a course for failing to have the necessary prerequisites.

4. UWO Policy on Accommodation for Medical Illness: Students seeking academic accommodation on medical grounds for any missed tests, exams, participation components and or assignments must apply to their Academic Counseling Office of their home Faculty and provide documentation. Academic accommodation cannot be granted by the instructor or department.

Please go to the following site for information on the university Policy on Accommodation for Medical Illness: www.uwo.ca/univsec/handbook/appeals/accommodation_medical.pdf

For information on the examination services provided by the Student Development Centre, please visit
www.sdc.uwo.ca/ssd

5. Mental Health: Students who are in emotional/mental distress should refer to Mental Health@Western for a complete list of options about how to obtain help.
http://www.uwo.ca/uwocom/mentalhealth/

6. Complaints: If students have a complaint concerning a course in which they are enrolled, they must discuss the matter with the instructor of the course. If students are still not satisfied, they should then take the complaint to the Film Studies Office, University College, Room 80. These regulations are in place because a failure to follow these procedures creates the potential for injustices of various kinds affecting either the instructor or the students themselves, or both parties. Concerns should not be allowed to fester but should be raised with the instructor in a timely manner, so that they can be addressed in time to make a difference to the course.

GRADING CRITERIA

A+ (90-100)

- **Argument**: Clear development of a specific, challenging and original thesis. The writer has taken significant risks successfully; in the resulting piece, distinctive ideas and content have discovered their necessary distinctive form. Detailed reference to appropriate texts, with evidence of individual response. Ability not only to expound subject but to see it around–subtleties and ambiguities, qualifications and concessions, relations to other subjects, etc.
- **Presentation, structure**: Quotations well integrated into text. Proper paragraphs. Almost no typographical errors.
- **Language Skills**: Sentence structure correct, with full range of sentence types (compound,

complex, and compound-complex), with full range of punctuation (including semicolons, colons, dashes, parentheses). Graceful style, neither pompous nor breezy, and few errors.

· **Research/scholarship**: Evidence of effective, extensive and independent research, with proper documentation of sources. Quotations used appropriately and purposively.

A (80 to 89)

· **Argument**: The writer has taken risks and most of them succeed. Clear development of a specific and challenging thesis, with proper paragraphs. Detailed reference to appropriate texts, with evidence of individual response. Ability not only to expound subject but to see it around–subtleties and ambiguities, qualifications and concessions, relations to other subjects, etc.

· **Presentation, structure:** Quotations well integrated into text. Proper paragraphs. Almost no typographical errors.

· **Language Skills:** Sentence structure correct, with full range of sentence types (compound, complex, and compound-complex), with full range of punctuation (including semicolons, colons, dashes, parentheses). Graceful style, neither pompous nor breezy, and few errors

· **Research/scholarship:** Evidence of effective and independent research, with proper documentation of sources. Quotations used appropriately and purposively.

B (70 to 79)

· **Argument:** Clear development of a specific thesis, with proper paragraphs. Adequately detailed reference to texts. Ability to expound reasonably sophisticated ideas with clarity.

· **Presentation/structure:** Quotations well integrated into text. Proper paragraphs. A few typographical errors.

· **Language Skills:** Sentence structure correct, with reasonable range of sentence types and full range of punctuation. Style not too wordy, with errors relatively few and minor.

· **Research Scholarship:** Evidence of adequate research, with proper documentation of sources.

C (60 to 69)

· **Argument:** Reasonably clear development of a thesis, with proper paragraphs. Basic ability to expound ideas, whose development might be rather thin. Effort to support points with references to the text. Tendency to replace analysis with descriptive retelling of plot.

· **Presentation/structure:** Presentation showing lapses in tidiness and/or proofreading. Poor use of paragraphs.

· **Language Skills:** Sentence structure correct, but perhaps overly simple, with tendency to avoid punctuation besides period and comma. Errors relatively few, but occasionally serious, with evident misunderstanding of some point of elementary grammar (comma splices, fragments, semicolon errors, subject-verb disagreements, poorly integrated quotations)

- **Research/Scholarship:** reasonable effort at documentation, but rather thin.

D (50 to 59)

- **Argument:** Difficulty with paragraphing or consecutive thought. Ideas inchoate but clouded by weak expression. Overgeneralization with inadequate support, or examples that run to lengthy paraphrase, with little or no analysis.
- **Presentation/Structure:** Very poor to non-existent use of paragraphs. Inadequate and inaccurate documentation. Multiple typographical errors.
- **Language Skills:** Errors of grammar or diction frequent enough to interfere with understanding.
- **Research/Scholarship:** Little serious effort to research the topic.

F (49 and down)

- **Argument:** Ideas too simple for level of course. Argument completely incoherent. Erroneous content showing little or no understanding of subject.
- **Presentation/Structure:** Very sloppy proof-reading. Documentation virtually non-existent.
- **Language Skills:** writing frequently ungrammatical.
- Research/Scholarship: Non-existent. Content largely "borrowed" from sources with no individual distillation, but no apparent attempt to deceive.

0 (Report to Department)

- Plagiarism with intent to deceive